

Notes on The Effect An Introduction to Research Design and Causality by Nick Huntington-Klein

Chapter 1 - Designing Research

What is a research question

A research question is a clear, focused question that your study is designed to answer. It states exactly what issue, relationship, or phenomenon you want to investigate.

Key elements:

- It is based on a research problem or gap in existing knowledge and points to what needs further investigation.
- It guides the entire research process: what data you collect, which methods you use, and how you analyze and interpret results.

Good research questions are:

- Specific, concise, and understandable to others without extra explanation.
- Researchable (you can answer them with data) and open-ended enough that the answer is not trivial or already known.

Research question types

There are several common ways to classify research question types. The main ones you'll see in methodology texts are:

By logical aim:

- **Descriptive** – ask “what is...?” or “how much/how many...?” and aim to describe characteristics, patterns, or prevalence.
 - Example: “What are the main factors influencing customer churn in telecom companies?”
- **Relational / correlational** – ask about relationships between variables, without necessarily claiming causality.
 - Example: “Is there a relationship between weekly screen time and self-reported stress levels among adults?”
- **Causal / explanatory** – ask whether one variable causes or affects another.
 - Example: “What is the effect of participation in a data-literacy training program on analysts’ report accuracy?”